

Ambrosiaster 384

In 1 Tim. 3:14–15 — the pillar and ground of truth: the house whose ruler today is Damasus (CSEL 81/3, p. 270)

3:14. These things I write to you, hoping to come to you soon; 15. but if I should be delayed, [I write] that you may know how one ought to conduct oneself in the house of God, which is the church of the living God, the pillar and ground of the truth. 1. As far as his own knowledge went, his expectation was this — that he would see him rather soon; but because it is wont that something else should please God, whose providence is known to Himself alone, therefore — lest perchance, he says, I be delayed — I write to you, that you may know how you are to order the church, which is the house of God: so that, although the whole world is God's, the church is nevertheless called His house — whose ruler today is Damasus. 2. For the world is in transgression, thrown into confusion by manifold error. Therefore the house of God, and the truth, must be said to be there where He is feared according to His own will; and, since the servants profess concerning Him that which He Himself deigned to teach, He sealed these things — lest perchance His words should be denied to be His — with mighty works that can be done by no one else, so that by them unbelief, being convicted, may perish without excuse. For the signs and portents are the ground of this truth.

In Eph. 4:11–14 — the orders of the church; merit, not seniority, makes the bishop; the faith Peter professed (CSEL 81/3, pp. 98–102)

4:11. And He Himself gave some indeed to be apostles, some however prophets, others truly evangelists, some truly pastors and teachers, 12. for the perfecting of the saints unto the work of the ministry. 1. The apostles are bishops; the prophets, however, are expounders of the scriptures. Although in the very beginnings there were prophets — such as Agabus and the four prophesying virgins, as is contained in the Acts of the Apostles, {but} for the sake of commending the rudiments of the faith — now, however, they are called interpreters [rather than “prophets”]. The evangelists are deacons, as was Philip. Although they are not priests, they can nevertheless evangelize without a [bishop's] chair, just as Stephen too and the aforementioned Philip. The pastors can be lecturers, who feed with readings the listening people, because man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word of God. 2. The teachers, however, are exorcists, because in the church it is they who restrain and chastise the unquiet — or [they are] those who used to imbue with readings the infants [i.e. catechumens] that were to be imbued, as is the custom of the Jews, whose tradition passed over to us, [though] it has fallen out of use through neglect. Among these, [the one] next after the bishop is understood to be greater, who, on account of the unlocked hidden sense of the scriptures, is said to prophesy — especially because he brings forth words of future hope — which order cannot be that of

the presbyterate. For in the bishop are all the orders, since he is also (because he is) the first priest, that is, the chief of priests, and prophet and evangelist and the rest, for the fulfilling of the offices of the church in the ministry of the faithful. 3. Nevertheless, after the churches were established in all places and the offices ordained, the matter was arranged otherwise than it had begun. For at first all taught and all baptized, on whatever days or times there was occasion. For Philip did not seek a time or a day on which to baptize the eunuch, nor interpose a fast; nor did Paul and Silas defer the time in which to baptize the jailer with all his [household]; nor did Peter have clerics or seek a day when he baptized Cornelius with his whole house — nor did he [baptize] himself, but bade the brethren who had gone with him to Cornelius from Joppa; for as yet, besides the seven deacons, no one had been ordained. 4. So then, that the people might grow and be multiplied, it was granted to all, in the beginnings, both to evangelize and to baptize and to expound the scriptures in the church. But when the church had embraced all places, assemblies were established, and rectors and the other offices were ordained for the churches, so that no one of the clergy who had not been ordained should dare to presume an office which he knew had not been entrusted or granted to him. And the church began to be governed by another order and providence, because, if all could do the same things, it would be unreasonable, and the thing would seem common and most cheap. Hence, then, it is, that now neither do deacons preach among the people, nor do the rest, or laymen, baptize, nor on any [chance] day are believers washed except the sick. 5. Therefore the writings of the Apostle do not in all respects agree with the ordinance which is now in the church, because these things were written in the very beginnings. For he even calls Timothy, a presbyter ordained by himself, a bishop, because the first presbyters were called bishops, so that, when the one departed, the next should succeed him. Finally, in Egypt the presbyters seal [i.e. confirm], if a bishop be not present. But because the following presbyters began to be found unworthy to hold the primacies, the plan was changed, foresight providing for it, so that not order [seniority] but merit should make a bishop, appointed by the judgment of many priests, lest an unworthy man should rashly usurp [the office] and be a scandal to many. 6. Under the law, priests were born of the stock of Aaron, [being] Levites. But now all are of a priestly stock, as Peter the apostle says: “For we are,” he says, “a royal and priestly race”; and therefore from [among] the people a priest can be made.

“Unto the building up of the body of Christ.” He says that the ordinance of the church, unto the joining-together of the human race, was composed in unity of profession, so that — {though diverse in dignity} — in Christ all may be one, having Christ as head, that is, the author of life.

4:13. “Until we all meet into the unity of the faith and the acknowledgment of the Son of God.” He says that the ordinance [ordained ministry] remains for just so long, until all who are destined for life be of one faith unto the knowledge of Christ.

“Into a perfect man, into the measure of the age of the fullness of Christ.” Thus he exhorts [us] to labor, that the perfection of the faith may be grasped — the rationale of which is this: that faith may hold Christ to be perfect and full God, lest He be measured by a human measure, but be held, in the fullness of divinity, as [it were] perfect God. For in saying “a perfect man” he does not signify [it] by temporal age and measure, but by this saying he wishes us to be made perfect in the fullness of the understanding of the divinity of the Son of God.

4:14. “That we be no longer little children, nor wavering, and carried about by every wind of doctrine, in the wickedness of men, in craftiness, unto the contrivance of error.” He wishes us to be founded and stable in the discipline of the catholic faith, which Peter the apostle, at God’s revealing, professed; and not to be blown about, straying, through the pestilential assertions of the various heresies, devised by human wickedness, so that

through these the error of the deceiving enemy might be brought in under the name of truth. For this is the device of falsehood: that under the pretext of truth it may induce error. {And not only under the name of truth, but also lest — just as, before we received the faith, lowly in mind, we wandered through diverse errors — having been made faithful we should [now] run about, fragile and doubtful concerning the promised hope, he admonishes [us], because, having now been made Christians, we ought to be founded, since there is no ambiguity in our faith; for it is commended by the power of miracles.}

In 2 Thess. 2:1–8 — the discessio as the fall of the Roman kingdom (CSEL 81/3, pp. 238–241)

2:1. Now we beseech you, brethren, concerning the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ and our gathering-together unto Him, 2. that you be not readily moved from your understanding, nor be troubled, neither by spirit, nor by word, nor by epistle as though sent from us, as if the day of the Lord were at hand. 3. Let no one deceive you in any way; for [it will not come] unless the falling-away come first, and that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition, 4. who opposes and exalts himself above all that is called God, or that is worshipped, so that he sits in the temple of God, showing himself as though he were God. 1. He beseeches them not lightly and readily to entertain an opinion about the coming of the Lord as though imminent; and he gives such commands [as these]: that even if someone should have spoken through the spirit as a prophet, he ought not to be believed; nor, if [it come] through a treatise or through an epistle written perchance in the name of the apostles, is assent to be granted. For dissemblers are wont, in order to deceive, to forge an epistle under the name of some illustrious man, so that the authority of the name may commend what of itself could not be received. [He says] this for this reason: lest by that very disturbance, while [men] were found off their guard, they might be seduced into worshipping the devil — who for this reason will vaunt these things, that, appearing under the name of the Savior and deceiving the saints, he may wish to be worshipped, so as to deceive those who believe in Christ. 2. But so that the most shameless Satan may not have the place or occasion of deceiving which he thinks he has, [the Apostle] has marked out the time and signs of the Lord's coming: [namely] that the Lord will not come before the falling-away of the Roman kingdom take place, and Antichrist appear [beforehand], who will slay the saints, liberty being restored to the Romans — yet under his own name. For, knowing that the Lord will come to crush him, he will usurp His name for himself, and, that his kingdom may seem to be true and may draw along with itself those who are to perish together with him, [he acts] so that he may sit in the house of the Lord, in the seat of Christ, so as to assert himself to be God Himself, not the Son of God. 3. Whence in the Gospel the Lord says to the Jews: "I have come in the name of my Father, and you have not received me; if another shall come in his own name, him you will receive." Wherefore he [Antichrist] is to be expected to come from the circumcision, or circumcised, so that the Jews may have confidence to believe him. And so, when the Apostle writes to the Thessalonians, he teaches that all ought to be on their guard in a matter of this kind.

2:5. Do you not remember that, when I was still with you, these things were told you? 6. And now you know what withholds, to this end, that he may be revealed in his own time. He says that this remains: that he be revealed who is to come before the Lord, so that now the Lord too may be hoped [to be] coming. This he had above uttered, as it were, under a veil, saying: "unless the falling-away come first" — which [falling-away] I mentioned above as to be understood [as] the abolition of the Roman kingdom — so that, when it shall have failed and Antichrist shall have come, then the coming of the Lord may be believed to be at hand.

2:7. For the mystery of iniquity is already at work, only that he who now holds may hold, until he be taken out of the way. The mystery of iniquity was begun from Nero, who, out of zeal for the idols, slew even the apostles — his father the devil instigating [him] — down to Diocletian and, most recently, Julian, who by a certain art and subtlety could not carry through the persecution he had begun, because it had not been granted from above. For Satan uses these as his ministers, that meanwhile, under the throng of gods, he may make a mockery of the manifestation of the one true God, for the seducing of men — so long as the kingdom of the Romans shall stand: this is what he said, “until he be taken out of the way.”

2:8. And then shall that wicked one be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will slay with the breath of His mouth, and will destroy with the brightness of His presence: 9. whose coming is according to the working of Satan, in all power and signs and lying wonders. 1. He says that after the failure of the Roman kingdom Antichrist will appear, as has been mentioned. For in the last time the devil, knowing his own destruction to be imminent — and, the Roman kingdom failing, he too will be sent down from the heavens, cast forth onto the earth, as is said in the Apocalypse of the apostle John — will suborn for himself [one] in whom and through whom, working certain signs of power by the permission of the just God, he may commend himself to be worshipped, as though he were God. For he will imitate [God]: that, just as the Son of God, born or made man, demonstrated His own divinity by signs and mighty works, so also Satan will appear in a man, so as to show himself God by lying wonders, as was said above. 2. Now the revelation of the mystery of iniquity is this: when {indeed} Antichrist shall have appeared, he himself will be recognized to be, as it were, the god of those whom the crowd formerly worshipped as gods at his nod, of whom he himself is the first or the highest — which he will make credible by the [feigned] power of signs. Therefore he called them lying portents, because he wishes himself to be believed, through signs, [to be] that which he is not, so as to deceive those whom he is about to encompass [in ruin]. Which was foretold to the saints for this reason: that they may know what to beware of.

Quaestiones CX (De psalmo primo), §§ 5–7 — the seat of pestilence versus the order begun from Peter (CSEL 50, pp. 271–274)

5. Next he added: “and has not sat in the seat of pestilence.” He says that this is the blessedness which stands upon these three degrees and is fortified by a threefold rationale — namely, that one neither go into the counsel of the ungodly, nor stand in the way of sinners, nor sit in the seat of pestilence. But since only two kinds [of men] are held [in view] — of the ungodly and of sinners — in the censure of the things mentioned above, to which [kind] did he wish this third to be assigned, which he added, saying: “and has not sat in the seat of pestilence”? To the ungodly, or to sinners? But let us see what it is to sit in the seat of pestilence, and then we shall understand to which kind he assigns this. We call that the seat of pestilence which is outside the ordinance of God, which has been devised precisely for this — that unjust judgments may issue from it; for that reason it is called the seat of pestilence, which is a corruption that begets death, just as iniquity [begets] damnation. That, therefore, is not from God which is the seat of death; for Moses received the seat of life. For it was given for this: that in it there should be the authority of a just judge, or [rather] of God the creator. Whence the Lord says: “Upon the seat of Moses have sat the scribes and Pharisees”; and the Apostle: “There is no power,” he says, “but from God; for those that are, are ordained by God.”

6. Whence he says to the ruler of the people: “Do you indeed sit judging according to the law, and against the law order me to be struck?” In that he said “according to the law,” he signified the just and salutary authority of the seat. But that which he says — “against the law you order me to be struck” — shows that judge himself to be unjust, in that, sitting in the seat of God, he judged unjustly. Hence it is that Daniel too [says]: “The kingdom is God’s,” he says, “and to whom He wills He will give it.” As, therefore, the authority of an earthly emperor runs through all, so that in all there may be reverence for him, so God has ordained that from the king himself the authority of God should begin and run through all. Although frequently the world does not understand this, and one set in power subjects himself [to another] more than he ought, nevertheless the ordinance is that there be one who is feared. Where, therefore, this ordinance is not, there the seat of pestilence is found. Nowhere is the authority of the one God refused, except among those who preach the fear and reverence of many gods. These are they who sit in the seat of pestilence, because what their pontiffs preach is death. For they teach this: that the worshippers of the one God should either — as fools and enemies — be held in reproach, or be taken out of this life. This very thing is the matter of impiety, which extends also into other areas, through which it may set forth the laws of its own impiety. For at Jezebel’s command the presiders of iniquity sat in the seat of pestilence, who, against innocent Naboth, though they were not judges, plotting wicked things, by suborned false witnesses passed a sentence of death. Whence in another psalm he says: “and I will not sit with the ungodly.” For this is his judgment, whose also is the seat of pestilence. And so, if, sitting in the seat of God, they oppress the innocent, it will be the judgment that is unjust, not the seat. For where the seat of pestilence is, the judgment cannot but be iniquitous — although they apply to themselves certain veils, as it were, with which to cover their impiety, so that the seeing may be deceived. For impiety cannot be set forth alone, because it finds no buyer; and, where the law of the devil is, if it be named [openly], it is shuddered at.
7. Just as [poison] is mixed in with something through which it may lie hidden, so also to the law of the devil they mix in certain just things and apply the name of truth; but the sense of each single [statement] must be judged, because it sometimes shows something true precisely in order to deceive — so that, when it proclaims malignant things, they may be thought good. Since we have asserted that the seat of pestilence is not from the ordinance of God, we say that the seat of those also who, outside the church or against the church, have set up seats for themselves, is a seat of pestilence. For he who presumes upon things not permitted is guilty: how much more if he also corrupts the tradition of him whose seat he usurps! For they disturb the order begun from the apostle Peter and preserved down to this present time through the propagative succession of bishops following one upon another, claiming for themselves an order without origin — that is, professing a body without a head; whence it is fitting to call their seat too a seat of pestilence. Nor will it therefore go unpunished, that they do these things under the name of God. For it is agreed that those men plead their own causes under the name of God. For they do not do these things out of zeal for God, but wishing to defend a place for themselves — since we know that Korah and the two hundred and fifty men, offering to God through presumption, were swallowed up by the gaping of the earth, and that King Uzziah, when he had offered unlawfully to God, was struck with leprosy on the forehead.